

Children and Frogs

The big fat head seems too big for the teeny tiny body. I mean, where's the neck? But that just makes them cuter, except when they're sticky or slimy, a frequent occurrence with both children and frogs. Did you know that at night, frogs make croaking noises that wake you up? So do babies. Bet you didn't know that already. Frogs go through developmental stages: egg, tadpole, froglet, adult. Children go through developmental stages: parasite, tornado, civil rights activist, therapy patient. In one of my favorite comics, Hobbes tells Calvin that frogs "drink water all day just in case someone picks them up," and believe me, it's the same with kids, as my dad could attest from his experiences with the "surprise diaper firehose." Children like jumping. Frogs like jumping. Frogs eat so many bugs, children eat soooo many fruit snacks. Frogs are eaten by humans around the world.

The oldest recorded myth of child cannibalism occurred when the great titan Cronus swallowed his children because they would one day overthrow him. Likewise, each population in Europe threatens children with its own version of the hungry adult.

The Germans: Hansel and Gretel.

The Norwegians: Buttercup.

The Frenchies: Hop o' My Thumb.

The Russians: Baba Yaga.

Perhaps these fairy tales helped children not talk to strangers, walk in the forest, or ignore their parents. I imagine in my head a mother threatening her children, "If you don't behave, I will lock you outside the house for the ogre to eat." The mother says it to keep her kids in line, to show her control. To say, "Your existence depends on convenience, not love." Unfortunately for children, real life is rarely convenient.

St. Jerome recounts, "the starving people had recourse to hideous food and tore each other limb from limb that they might have flesh to eat. Even the mother did not spare the babe at her breast." This in CE 409, as the Visigoths laid siege to Rome. During the European famine lasting between 1032 and 1035, children were lured with apples, killed, and eaten.

Abd al Latif said that during a famine in 13th century Cairo, you could count the children mixed in a pot based on the number of feet inside. Little children could be found for sale on street corners, boiled or roasted. Entrepreneurs hunted down street children for food and extra income. The people, "eventually ... grew accustomed, and some conceived such a taste for these detestable meats that they made them their ordinary provender ... The horror people had felt at first vanished entirely."

Okay, prep yourself, we're going on a little tangent. I would never, ever, eat a child, I tell myself. Even if I was starving. But what if it isn't a famine I'm facing? What if instead, I'm just in a society that doesn't have children? Cronus ate his kids because they would get in the way of his reign, his lifestyle. We're living Cronus' lifestyle. The previous quote applies to us just as well: "accustomed, and some conceived such a taste for these detestable meats..." We're not eating children, we're just choosing not to have them because they get in the way of our reign, our lifestyle.

I'm rooming with my youngest brother Joshua right now. We sing, we dance, we share the car. I would be so lonely if I didn't have him, or Benjamin, or Hyrum—or Enoch, Jessica, and Cecil. It's a big family by today's standards. But I'm big happy by today's standards, too. I have a family I can go to for support. However, I grapple, I really grapple, with the way some families don't support each other. They argue, never show up; sometimes it's worse than not having any family at all. After experiencing a family like that, children, like frogs, sound gross and disgusting. But if we're "too busy to have kids," we never accept children into our lives at all. I mean, not giving birth also conveniently removes the danger of our eating our kids, but we'd never care for them either. And I think that's what helps me un-grapple: I have a responsibility to birth and raise children, not just to prevent their cannibalization. Whew. Feels good to get that out.

Psst, hey, global frog populations started to decline in the 1960s. Frog populations dropping are an early alarm for ecosystem death. There's no real connection between children and frogs, just some parallels. No reason to pay attention to them. Go to bed. Sweet dreams.